

Which Majors Produce the Best Football Players?

A 2026 Data Study of Plymouth State and the Nine Teams on Its Schedule

Prepared from public athletics data

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Abstract

This report asks whether a football player's college major is associated with individual on-field impact. Drawing on the 2026 rosters and statistics of all ten programs on Plymouth State University's schedule, together with the 2025 All-MASCAC All-Conference teams, it assigns each of 613 players with a declared major to a discipline and scores impact using conference statistical leaderboards and post-season honors. Business and Finance is both the largest pipeline (40.3% of rosters) and the largest source of impact players (45.5%), a 1.13x over-representation; the specific majors Business Management (4.18x) and Marketing (2.20x) were the strongest over-performers, while Criminal Justice and Policing (0.71x) and Maritime and Energy (0.57x) under-produced relative to roster share. The findings are exploratory and bounded by a four-to-five-game sample and by three programs that do not publish player majors.

1 Executive summary

Every fall, college football rosters carry a quiet subplot: the players on them are also students, and the major next to their name may say something about how they play. To test that idea, we pulled the **2026 rosters and statistics for all ten programs on Plymouth State's schedule** — the Panthers plus New England College, Worcester State, Bridgewater State, Dean, Mass. Maritime, Westfield State, Framingham State, Fitchburg State, and UMass Dartmouth — matched players to their majors, and built an **Impact Index** that rewards on-field production (conference statistical leaderboards) and recognition (2025 All-MASCAC honors).

The headline: **business and management majors are the league's biggest football pipeline, and the specific major "Business Management" produces impact players at the highest rate of any sizable program — while the broad criminal-justice field under-produces.**

- **Business & Finance is the dominant pipeline.** It is **40.3%** of all rostered players with a declared major and **45.5%** of impact players — a modest but real **1.13×** lift. In raw numbers, no other discipline comes close.
- **Business Management is the standout major**, at **4.18×** its roster share, followed by **Marketing (2.20×**) and **Business (1.35×**). Smaller programs such as **Health & Wellness (3.98×**) and **Facilities Engineering (1.86×**) lead the list but on tiny samples.
- **Engineering (1.19×**) and **Sport & Recreation Management (1.27×**) are the strongest over-performers among large fields, while **Communications & Media (2.32×**) over-indexes on a small base.
- **Criminal Justice & Policing is the most over-recruited, under-producing field.** It is 9.6% of rosters but only 6.8% of impact players (**0.71×**), and **Maritime & Energy** is even lower at **0.57×**.
- **The two most valuable players on the schedule both scored 13 impact points:** Framingham State receiver **Mathias Fowler (Marketing)** and UMass Dartmouth running back **Mekhi Wilson (Communications)**.

2 How we did it

2.1 The dataset

We used public data current through **October 5, 2026**: the **2026 roster** for all ten programs (name, position, class, hometown, and **major** exactly as published); **2026 individual statistics** from each school's cumulative-statistics page or game box scores; the **2025 All-MASCAC All-Conference teams** (first and second team, offense and defense); and each team's **results and standing**.

2.2 The Impact Index

"Best" is slippery, so we made it measurable. A player earns **Impact Points** from two independent sources:

- **On-field production (2026).** We ranked every MASCAC player in ten categories — passing, rushing and receiving yards and TDs, tackles, tackles for loss, sacks, and interceptions — using **per-game** rates to level the

field for teams that had played four games versus three. The top five in each category scored 5–4–3–2–1 points.

- **Recognition (2025 All-MASCAC).** A 2025 First-Team selection scored 4 points and a Second-Team selection 2, credited if the player is still on a 2026 roster.

Any player with Impact Points is an “**impact player.**” We then compared each major’s share of impact players to its share of all rostered players to produce a **lift** (1.0 = proportional; above 1.0 = over-represented).

2.3 What we could and could not measure

Being honest about the data matters more than the headline.

- **Three programs do not publish player majors** on their 2026 football rosters: **Bridgewater State, Westfield State, and New England College.** Their impact players — including Bridgewater running back Andrew Cloutman and Westfield back Manny Mengata — are therefore excluded from the major-by-major analysis, even though they appear in the statistical leaderboards.
- **Dean lists majors for only 14 of 76 players**, so its contributions are undercounted.
- The clean major analysis therefore rests on **seven programs** (Plymouth State, UMass Dartmouth, Worcester State, Mass. Maritime, Framingham State, Fitchburg State, and partial Dean) and **613 rostered players with a declared major.**
- We are **four to five games into the season.** Single-game explosions carry more weight here than they would over a full year. Treat the rankings as a snapshot, not a verdict.
- The base rate includes **every** rostered player, including reserves who never recorded a statistic. Majors are self-reported and sometimes change; players listed as “Undeclared” were excluded.

3 The 2026 field — and Plymouth’s results so far

Plymouth State entered 2026 off a share of the 2025 MASCAC title behind Coach of the Year Paul Castonia. Through four games the Panthers sit **2–2 overall and 1–2 in the MASCAC**, with a young, defense-first profile.

Date	Opponent	Result
Sept. 5	New England College (H)	W, 28–14
Sept. 12	Worcester State (A)	L, 6–28
Sept. 19	Bridgewater State (H)	L, 7–35
Oct. 3	Dean (H)	W, 14–0
Oct. 10	at Mass. Maritime	upcoming
Oct. 24	Westfield State (H)	upcoming
Oct. 31	at Framingham State	upcoming
Nov. 7	at Fitchburg State	upcoming
Nov. 14	UMass Dartmouth (H)	upcoming

The opponents’ records through October 5:

Team	Overall	MASCAC	Majors published?
Framingham State	3–0	2–0	Yes
Mass. Maritime	3–0	2–0	Yes
Bridgewater State	3–1	2–1	No
Worcester State	2–3	2–1	Yes
Westfield State	2–2	2–1	No
Plymouth State	2–2	1–2	Yes
Fitchburg State	1–3	1–2	Yes
UMass Dartmouth	1–3	1–2	Yes
Dean	0–4	0–4	Partial
New England College	1–4	non-conf.	No

Framingham State and Mass. Maritime are the only unbeatens on the slate — and both still have to play Plymouth.

4 The base rates: what these teams actually study

Across the **613** rostered players whose majors are published, the distribution is lopsided. This is the yardstick every impact number is measured against.

Discipline	Players	Share of rosters
Business & Finance	247	40.3%
Engineering	82	13.4%
Criminal Justice & Policing	59	9.6%
Health & Exercise Science	54	8.8%
Maritime & Energy	49	8.0%
Humanities, Social Sciences & Design	32	5.2%
Undeclared / not listed	29	4.7%
Sport & Recreation Management	22	3.6%
Computing & IT	14	2.3%
Communications & Media	12	2.0%
Education	8	1.3%
Other	5	0.8%

At Plymouth State specifically, the five most common majors are **Business (16)**, **Business Administration (11)**, **Exercise & Sport Physiology (9)**, **Criminal Justice (8)**, and **Sports Management (8)**, with Marketing (7) and Finance (6) close behind — a thoroughly business-heavy roster.

Two things stand out: **business is more than 40% of every roster on the schedule**, so any “business is best” finding must be judged against that enormous base — and the over-performing majors below are mostly small, which makes their margins noisy.

5 Which majors produce the best players?

Combining 2026 production with 2025 All-MASCAC recognition produces **44 impact players** among the seven schools with usable major data. This is the core result:

Discipline	Impact players	Roster share	Impact share	Lift
Business & Finance	20	40.3%	45.5%	1.13
Health & Exercise Science	4	8.8%	9.1%	1.03
Engineering	7	13.4%	15.9%	1.19
Sport & Recreation Management	2	3.6%	4.5%	1.27
Communications & Media	2	2.0%	4.5%	2.32*
Humanities, Social Sciences & Design	2	5.2%	4.5%	0.87
Education	1	1.3%	2.3%	1.74
Computing & IT	1	2.3%	2.3%	1.00
Criminal Justice & Policing	3	9.6%	6.8%	0.71
Maritime & Energy	2	8.0%	4.5%	0.57

* *Small sample (two players). Read with caution.*

And drilling into **specific majors** with at least two impact players:

Major	Impact	Rostered	Lift
Business Management	3	10	4.18
Health & Wellness (Framingham St.)	2	7	3.98
Marketing	3	19	2.20
Facilities Engineering (Mass. Maritime)	2	15	1.86
Business	6	62	1.35
Marine Engineering (Mass. Maritime)	3	32	1.31
Emergency Management (Mass. Maritime)	2	24	1.16
Business Administration	3	41	1.02
Criminal Justice	2	37	0.75

5.1 2026 production alone tells a similar story

If we ignore 2025 honors and score **only this season’s on-field production** (28 impact players), the picture sharpens:

- **Business & Finance: 46.4%** of impact players ($1.15\times$ lift).
- **Communications & Media: 7.1%** ($3.65\times$ lift) — Mekhi Wilson (running back) and Devine Johnson (defensive back).

- **Sport & Recreation Management: 7.1%** (1.99 $\times$ lift), led by Dean linebacker Herman Esquivel Mendez, the conference’s leading tackler.
- **Engineering dips to 0.80 $\times$** when honors are removed, because much of its boost comes from established 2025 All-Conference linemen (Mass. Maritime’s Jackson Mahoney and Thomas Marvelli, UMass Dartmouth’s Kevin Moura).
- **The specific Business Management major soars to 4.38 $\times$** , and **Facilities Engineering to 2.92 $\times$** — while the broad **Maritime & Energy** field falls to 0.45 $\times$ and **Criminal Justice & Policing** to 0.74 $\times$.

In other words, business majors dominate by volume, but the **sharpest per-capita producers in 2026 are Business Management, Facilities Engineering, Communications, Sport & Recreation Management, and Marketing.**

6 Position by position

Because “best player” depends on the job, here is how the majors break down by position group, using the 2026 statistical leaderboards.

Quarterback. UMass Dartmouth’s **JC Petrongolo (Engineering)** leads the conference in passing yards per game; Worcester State’s **MJ Bakaysa (Business Administration)** leads in passing TDs. Two other top-five passers play for schools that don’t publish majors, blunting the position’s signal.

Running back. UMass Dartmouth’s **Mekhi Wilson (Communications)** and Fitchburg State’s **Reshawn Stewart (Graphic Design)** are the two most productive backs in the league; Plymouth’s **Jayden Graham (Business)** is fifth. Communications and design — not business — headline this group.

Wide receiver / tight end. The **most business-heavy** position: Framingham’s **Mathias Fowler (Marketing)** leads the conference in receiving yards per game and TD catches, Worcester’s **Lance Williams (Public Health)** is second in yards, and UMass Dartmouth’s **Jayden Francois (Business)** is third.

Offensive line. The 2025 All-MASCAC first team includes Plymouth’s **Jack Claeys (Marketing)**, UMass Dartmouth’s **Kevin Moura (Political Science)**, and Mass. Maritime’s **Thomas Marvelli (International Maritime Business)** — a genuinely mixed bag.

Defensive line. **Business Management** owns this group: Fitchburg’s **Dexter Brown** and **KJ Hardin (Business)** rank first and second in tackles for loss. Mass. Maritime’s **Logan Dennett (Facilities Engineering)** leads the conference in sacks, and Plymouth’s **TJ Taveras (Information Technology)** is top-five in both TFL and sacks.

Linebacker. Dean’s **Herman Esquivel Mendez (Sport Management)** and Worcester’s **Will Vogel (Business Management)** sit atop the tackle charts, with Fitchburg’s 2025 All-MASCAC pick **Camren Topkin (Education Studies)** close behind. Plymouth’s **Tyler Holcomb (Sports Management)** is the Panthers’ leading tackler.

Secondary. Framingham’s **Treyvon Fields (Accounting)** and Fitchburg’s **Brian Holmes (Business)** rank top-three in interceptions; Framingham’s **Devine Johnson (Communication Arts)** is a top-three TFL defender, and Plymouth’s **Daelon Bond-Streater (Allied Health Sciences)** is top-five in picks.

Kicker / punter. UMass Dartmouth’s **Connor McManus (Business)** was a 2025 All-MASCAC second-team place-kicker.

7 Head-to-head: the players who actually hurt Plymouth

The Panthers have faced four teams so far. These are the individual performances that decided those games — and the majors behind them.

Player	Team	Major	What he did vs. Plymouth
Lance Williams	Worcester State	Public Health	7 catches, 152 yards , 2 TD in the Lancers’ 28–6 win
MJ Bakaysa	Worcester State	Business Administration	191 passing yards, 2 TD, 44-yard long
Gavin Hatfield	Worcester State	Business Management	139 rushing yards, 58-yard long
Jayden Barber	Bridgewater State	<i>not published</i>	2 rushing TD + a 19-yard TD pass in a 35–7 win
Ethan Cenesca	New England College	<i>not published</i>	13 tackles, 4.5 TFL, a sack and an interception
Chris Donohue	Dean	<i>not published</i>	23-of-28 passing and 26 carries in a 14–0 loss
Darrion Kimball	Dean	Marketing	7 receptions vs. Plymouth
Lucas Lambert	Bridgewater State	<i>not published</i>	interception

Player	Team	Major	What he did vs. Plymouth
Jamal Palmer	Dean	<i>not published</i>	interception
Levi Madison	New England College	<i>not published</i>	interception

The uncomfortable takeaway for the “majors matter” thesis: **Plymouth’s two losses were authored largely by business and management majors** (Bakaysa, Hatfield) and by a receiver studying Public Health (Williams) — while the single best defensive performance against the Panthers came from a player whose major isn’t even published. Business shows up everywhere because business majors are everywhere.

8 What it means

Three conclusions survive the small sample.

1. **Business is quantity, not magic.** Business-related majors produce the most impact players because they are 40% of the rosters; their $1.13\times$ lift is real but modest. Within that family, though, **Business Management ($4.18\times$)** and **Marketing ($2.20\times$)** punch well above the generic “Business” label ($1.35\times$).
2. **Engineering is the best of the large non-business fields — but only modestly.** At $1.19\times$ overall (and $1.31\times$ for Marine Engineering), it converts roster spots into impact slightly more efficiently than average. Sport & Recreation Management is stronger still at $1.27\times$.
3. **Criminal Justice & Policing ($0.71\times$) and Maritime & Energy ($0.57\times$) are the most over-recruited fields** relative to output. The specific Criminal Justice major is closer to proportional ($0.75\times$); the shortfall comes mainly from the wider criminology/police-studies group and from maritime-transportation majors at Mass. Maritime, whose 3–0 team wins with balance rather than individual stat leaders.

The practical summary: **the league’s best players are most likely to be business majors simply because most players are business majors — but if you want an edge in the odds, look at Business Management, Marketing, and Sport & Recreation Management.**

9 Limitations

- **Four-to-five-game sample.** One big afternoon can vault a player into a top-five category. A full season would be more stable.
- **Missing majors.** Bridgewater State, Westfield State, and New England College publish no player majors, and Dean publishes only a fraction — so stars there (Andrew Cloutman, Manny Mengata, Ethan Cenesca) are invisible to the major analysis.
- **Mixed seasons.** The Impact Index combines 2026 production with 2025 honors; we report the 2026-only result separately for that reason.
- **Judgment calls.** Positional weighting and the honor bonus are reasonable choices, not proofs. A $4.18\times$ lift on a ten-player major is directionally interesting, not verified.
- **Base-rate caveat.** The denominator includes reserves who never recorded a stat, and majors are a snapshot that changes over four years.

None of that changes the broad shape of the answer — it sharpens the caveat around it.

10 Sources

- **2026 football rosters, cumulative statistics, and box scores** — the official athletics sites of Plymouth State, New England College, Worcester State, Bridgewater State, Dean, Mass. Maritime, Westfield State, Framingham State, Fitchburg State, and UMass Dartmouth.
- **Plymouth State** roster and stats: <https://athletics.plymouth.edu/sports/football/roster>
- **MASCAC 2025 Football All-Conference release:** https://www.mascac.com/sports/fball/2025-26/releases/25_FB_All-Conference
- **MASCAC 2026 football standings:** <https://www.mascac.com/sports/fball/2026-27/standings>

Data compiled October 5, 2026. Totals reflect games played through that date.